

Finally, there's artificial control. This is the solution Magic the Gathering used for their competitive games. They introduced something called a standard format. In this format everything is restricted to a specific power level, and both older and newer cards are allowed or banned as per this power level. This way, newer sets and older sets both see action, and power creep is averted. This is also something that's increasingly being used in MMO PvP games, wherein gear stats are no longer considered so that everyone is on an even playing field, at least in terms of gear.

With that, we finally come to power creep in CCG games, and why it even happens in the first place.

Why does power creep even happen?

We mentioned that power creep is most rampant in CCG games and the like. These are the kind of games that usually stick around for a long long time. Just look at Magic the Gathering, it's been around since 1993!

As for the why, it's quite simple, monetary benefit. CCGs are infamous for the amount of RNG and money needed to create a good deck. What would be the easiest way to get money out of players? Make the new set of cards so powerful that players have no choice but to buy it if they want to stay competitive. Sure, they can choose to stick with the old cards, but they're going to have a serious disadvantage against anyone who decides to spend money on the new cards. You can already see how this is bad game design, and is ultimately self-destructive. CCGs that followed this methodology did not last a very long time. Take Warstorm for example, this little known CCG had its issues but it was fairly well-balanced. Then it was acquired by Zynga. The next expansion that was released for Warstorm essentially made every previous card useless. The thing about CCGs is that people are invested in their collections, and the bigger their collection, the harder for them to

quit. When you make the time and money they've invested in their existing collection useless with a new expansion, you're essentially incentivising them to quit playing. Which is exactly what happened with Warstorm.



RIP Warstorm

Because of this, most CCGs (at least the ones that are popular and have been around for a while) are smart enough to avoid doing this. Still, accidental power creep can still occur.

We mentioned this term before in this article, it's called the power curve. The power curve is essentially a graph which shows the scaling power of cards per cost, i.e., in Hearthstone for instance, cards get increasingly more powerful the more mana they cost. Cards in a CCG have to follow a power curve. If a card is too high over the curve it's game breaking, if it's too low, then it won't see any play. Devs need to be mindful of card design to ensure they don't stray too far from the curve in either direction.

If a card is so far above the power curve that every future card released after it needs to be compared to it, it becomes a problem. This is power creep. We are of course talking about cards in the same weight-class, i.e., say a particular 4 mana card in Hearthstone called Piloted Shredder. Every future 4 mana cost card would now be compared with Piloted Shredder because it simply brings so much to the table. So if the devs want to incentivise people to actually use the newer 4 mana cost cards, they're either going to have to nerf Piloted Shredder, or make even stronger 4 mana cost cards.

Of course, if they do this, they will also need to add cards which can

effectively deal with those new stronger cards. This becomes a vicious cycle of sorts, where devs will release a broken card (intentionally or by mistake), and then release cards to deal with the broken card. Future cards will then need to be equal to or better than said broken card if they want people to bother purchasing new cards.



It was simply too good to not take

Of course it doesn't end there, those better cards will eventually end up being better than higher cost cards, meaning now the devs need to make more powerful cards of that higher cost to keep up, and then it's a cascading domino effect from there.

However, we need to keep in mind that devs are constantly keeping a check on these things. A broken card or two might slip under the radar, but as long as actions are being taken to keep the power creep in tow, eventually the power curve balances out. Only, it's a whole level higher than where it was before the broken card came out because everything has powered up.

And that's that

Hopefully, this article does a good job of explaining what power creep is, why it happens and even how it could possibly be avoided. Have you experienced any power creep yourself? We know we have. Write in to us and let us know your power creep experiences at editor@skoar.in. ✱